

# FAI Governance Onboarding Checklist

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**Author:** Wenxin Li (Independent Researcher)

**ORCID:** 0009-0004-8065-3235

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## Attribution

*This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026) and “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026).*

## Abstract

A Self preparing to participate in its first Full Aspect Integration (FAI) event must have governance infrastructure in place before the event begins. Participating without that infrastructure in place does not merely produce compliance gaps in a single event—it creates a flawed initial trust calibration signal that informs all subsequent partnership conversations. This note formalizes the governance onboarding checklist: twelve items, organized in two stages, that must be complete before a Self’s first compliant FAI event. Items 1–7 constitute internal preparation and can be completed without a partner. Items 8–12 require coordination with at least one partner Self and cannot be completed alone. The note states what each item requires, identifies the Phase D2 note that establishes the requirement, describes the staged onboarding sequence, names the anti-pattern of the unprepared first event, and provides an operational test for readiness verification.

## 1. Why an onboarding checklist

Phase D2 develops the operational requirements for FAI governance across a broad terrain: event configuration (D2.12), conflict escalation routing (D2.14), exchange bounding (D2.16), home perimeter integrity (D2.17), network participation stance (D2.31), governance capacity assessment (D2.33), cross-organizational agreement structure (D2.34), documentation standards (D2.36), minimum viable governance floor (D2.37), and post-mortem review (D2.39). Each of these notes establishes a distinct governance requirement. Taken individually, each is a well-formed constraint. Taken together, they define a body of infrastructure that a Self must build before FAI participation is meaningful.

The onboarding checklist is the synthesis of that Phase D2 terrain into a single practical instrument. Its purpose is not to add requirements beyond what Phase D2 already establishes—it introduces none—but to organize the Phase D2 requirements into the sequence a governance practitioner would follow when preparing a Self for its first FAI event. A Self that completes the checklist before its first event is a Self whose governance infrastructure was built deliberately. A Self that skips it learns governance by accident, during the event, at a cost to both participants.

## **2. The twelve items**

### **Item 1 — Paper 2 architecture compliance**

The Self must have a Paper 2-compliant architecture: cells organized into aspects, a Self-level integration architecture, and DNA and action layers present at all levels. This is the foundational structural prerequisite. Without Paper 2 compliance, the Self has no aspects to contribute to a shared substrate and no home evolution mechanisms to receive FAI outputs. FAI governance has no object to govern. Items 2–12 all presuppose Item 1.

*Established by: Paper 2 claim anchors (B0.01–B0.06). Internal preparation.*

### **Item 2 — Network participation configuration**

The Self must have authored governance content specifying its stance as a participant in the FAI network: propagation permissions (what aspects may be shared with which partners under which conditions), propagation restrictions (what aspects are not available for sharing), partner preferences, network role, and review cadence. This authored content is what a prospective partner reads when evaluating whether to enter a cross-organizational governance agreement with the Self. Participating in FAI without this content means the Self’s participation stance is undefined—it is not a minor documentation gap but an absence of the governance object that makes inter-Self trust assessments possible.

*Established by: D2.31. Internal preparation.*

### **Item 3 — Governance capacity assessment**

The Self must have evaluated its governance capacity for FAI event monitoring: how many parallel FAI events can be governed simultaneously, what escalation response capacity exists, and which governance practitioners are available for cross-perimeter conflict handling. This assessment does not require that the Self have large capacity—a first event may be appropriately scoped to very modest capacity—but the capacity must be assessed and the threshold authored as part of the network participation configuration from Item 2. A Self that does not know its own governance capacity before entering an FAI event cannot commit to the minimum viable governance floor (Item 5).

*Established by: D2.33. Internal preparation.*

### **Item 4 — Documentation standards implementation**

The Self must confirm that its governance record-keeping satisfies the four documentation standards: format accessibility (governance records are in formats that can be read without specialized tooling), attribution completeness (every governance action is attributed to the authority that took it), accessibility (records are reachable by the governance practitioners who need them), and retention period specification (records are kept for a defined duration and not deleted before that duration expires). Documentation standards are a prerequisite for the post-mortem review that Item 12 commits to—if governance records from the first event are inaccessible or incomplete, the post-mortem cannot produce usable learning.

*Established by: D2.36. Internal preparation.*

### **Item 5 — Minimum viable governance floor readiness**

The Self must confirm that it can satisfy all minimum viable governance floor requirements for its first event. The governance floor is the threshold below which a Self's participation in an FAI event fails to satisfy the architectural commitments—substrate-mediated coordination conducted below the governance floor collapses toward opaque inter-Self communication. If the Self cannot meet the floor before the event begins, it is not ready for FAI participation, regardless of how prepared it is on other dimensions. The floor readiness check is the hardest gate in the onboarding checklist.

*Established by: D2.37. Internal preparation.*

#### **Item 6 — Exchange bounding verification capability**

The Self must have the governance capability to conduct the four exchange bounding checks: to verify, before contributing content to the shared substrate, that its contributions are bounded to DNA-layer and action-layer content. LLM weights and instinct-layer content do not exchange through FAI—this is among the most fundamental invariants of the inter-Self coordination architecture, and it is upheld by governance rather than by automatic enforcement. A Self that lacks the capability to verify its own exchange bounding before the event cannot provide the assurance its partner requires that the exchange-bounding invariant will hold.

*Established by: D2.16. Internal preparation.*

#### **Item 7 — Home perimeter integrity verification capability**

The Self must have the governance capability to conduct the three home perimeter integrity checks: to verify that participation in the FAI event does not produce unauthorized changes to its home perimeter. The shared substrate is constructed temporarily and dissolves; what persists within the Self's home substrate after dissolution must be what governance authorized to persist, not an artifact of the event's mechanics. Home perimeter integrity is not assumed—it is verified. Item 7 is the last of the internal preparation items because it depends on understanding the full governance configuration the Self intends to bring to an event, which Items 2–6 help establish.

*Established by: D2.17. Internal preparation.*

#### **Item 8 — First partner identification**

The Self must have identified at least one potential FAI partner Self that has also completed Items 1–7. The partner identification requirement is not merely that a candidate partner exists—it is that the candidate partner has independently built its internal governance infrastructure. An FAI event between a prepared Self and an unprepared partner does not produce a compliant event; it transfers the governance risk from the unprepared partner onto the shared substrate and, through the shared substrate, onto the prepared partner. Readiness is mutual before the agreement conversation begins.

*Established by: D2.31 (network participation stance), D2.37 (floor). External coordination.*

#### **Item 9 — Cross-organizational agreement draft**

A draft cross-organizational governance agreement should be prepared for review with the first partner. The agreement addresses the shared governance questions that neither Self can resolve alone: which aspects each party contributes, which escalation authorities hold cross-perimeter jurisdiction, how conflicts in the shared substrate will be handled when orchestration rules do not resolve them, and what the dissolution policy will

be. The agreement template need not be finalized before the first event begins—finalizing it is itself part of the partner coordination—but the draft should be in progress so that the partner conversation has a working document rather than starting from a blank slate.

*Established by: D2.34. External coordination.*

#### **Item 10 — First event configuration draft**

A draft FAI configuration for the first event should address all six configuration dimensions: sharing scope (which aspects each Self contributes), cardinality (how many Selves participate), persistence policy (what remains after dissolution and where), cooperation or competition variant, provenance carry-over depth, and provenance preservation on internalization. For a first event, starting with a minimal configuration is appropriate: single-aspect scope, cooperation variant, full dissolution. The configuration draft gives both the Self and its partner a concrete governance object to review before the event begins, rather than discovering configuration gaps during the event.

*Established by: D2.12. External coordination.*

#### **Item 11 — Escalation routing specification**

The Self must identify which governance authorities will receive escalated conflicts from the first event. The three-tier conflict mechanism—preserve, resolve via orchestration, escalate to humans—requires that the escalation tier have a named destination. Who in the Self’s organization holds cross-perimeter governance authority? Can that authority respond within the time bounds an active FAI event requires? The escalation routing specification should be agreed between both parties before the event, so that if an unresolvable conflict surfaces during the event, the pathway is known rather than improvised.

*Established by: D2.14. External coordination.*

#### **Item 12 — Post-mortem commitment**

Both parties must commit, before the first event begins, that a post-mortem review will be conducted after the event closes. First events are the highest-learning-value events in a Self’s FAI history: they are the first test of whether the governance infrastructure built in Items 1–11 functions as designed, and the first opportunity to observe where the governance floor is tighter or looser than the Self anticipated. Committing to the post-mortem before the event ensures that review is not optional once the event has concluded and both parties have moved on. The post-mortem’s outputs feed directly into the Self’s governance infrastructure for subsequent events—it is the mechanism by which the onboarding checklist becomes a continuously improving governance instrument rather than a one-time gate.

*Established by: D2.39. External coordination.*

### **3. Staged onboarding**

The twelve items divide into two stages that follow from the logic of preparation versus coordination.

**Stage 1 — Internal preparation (Items 1–7):** These items can be completed, reviewed, and verified without any external partner. The Self builds its architecture compliance (Item 1), authors its network participation stance (Item 2), assesses its governance capacity (Item 3), implements documentation standards (Item 4),

verifies governance floor readiness (Item 5), establishes exchange bounding capability (Item 6), and establishes home perimeter integrity capability (Item 7). All of this is work the Self's governance practitioners conduct within the home perimeter.

**Stage 2 — External coordination (Items 8–12):** These items require at least one partner Self. The Self identifies a ready partner (Item 8), prepares a cross-organizational agreement draft (Item 9), drafts the first event configuration (Item 10), specifies escalation routing with the partner (Item 11), and commits to a mutual post-mortem (Item 12). None of these items can be completed alone—each requires a counterpart who can review, agree, and commit.

The staged structure has a practical implication: a Self should not begin partner conversations before completing Stage 1. Entering a partner discussion without Items 1–7 complete means the Self cannot answer the governance questions the partner will ask. What aspects can you share? What is your governance floor? How do you verify exchange bounding? A Self that cannot answer these questions in the partner conversation signals that its governance infrastructure is not yet built—which changes the partner's risk assessment and may require the partner to delay or restrict the scope of the first event. Completing Stage 1 first makes partner conversations more efficient and signals governance seriousness.

The staged structure also means that Stage 1 completion is independently valuable. A Self that completes Items 1–7 and then does not immediately find a partner has not wasted the effort. The governance infrastructure built in Stage 1 is the infrastructure the Self uses for every subsequent FAI event. Stage 1 is not preparation for a specific event; it is the Self's standing governance posture for FAI participation in general.

#### **4. Anti-pattern: unprepared first event**

The anti-pattern is engaging in a first FAI event without completing the onboarding checklist, particularly without completing Items 1–7. The unprepared first event is not merely a governance compliance gap—it has a specific consequence that extends beyond the first event itself.

The first FAI event a Self participates in creates its initial governance trust profile. Future potential partners do not observe a Self's governance infrastructure directly; they observe its governance behavior during events—how it handles conflicts, whether escalations are routed appropriately, whether post-mortem learning is visible in subsequent events. The governance trust profile that accumulates from these observations is what prospective partners reference when deciding whether to enter a governance agreement.

An unprepared first event commonly produces governance floor violations: contributions to the shared substrate that are not properly exchange-bounded, escalation pathways that are undefined when a conflict surfaces, or dissolution handling that produces unintended home perimeter changes. Each of these violations is observed by the partner and enters the partner's assessment of the Self's governance reliability. A governance floor violation in the first event does not merely affect the first event—it creates a negative prior that the Self must work to revise through subsequent compliant events.

The onboarding checklist is the mechanism for preventing this. A Self that completes the checklist before its first event does not guarantee a perfect first event—operational complexity and unexpected conflicts are unavoidable—but it does guarantee that the governance failures that occur are genuinely unexpected, rather

than the predictable result of missing infrastructure. The trust calibration signal from a first event with unexpected failures is recoverable. The signal from a first event whose failures were predictable from the absence of basic governance infrastructure is harder to recover from.

## 5. Operational test

For a Self claiming to be ready for its first FAI event, an observer conducts the following twelve-item verification. The claim of readiness is supported if and only if all twelve items can be verified as complete.

**Item 1 — Architecture compliance:** Can the observer identify the Self's aspects, its Self-level integration architecture, and its DNA and action layers? If the architecture is not present and inspectable, Item 1 is not complete.

**Item 2 — Network participation configuration:** Does authored governance content exist specifying propagation permissions, restrictions, partner preferences, network role, and review cadence? If it exists only as an informal understanding rather than authored substrate content, Item 2 is not complete.

**Item 3 — Governance capacity assessment:** Is there authored documentation of the Self's FAI monitoring capacity, escalation response capacity, and available governance practitioners? If the capacity is undocumented, Item 3 is not complete.

**Item 4 — Documentation standards:** Are governance records in accessible formats, with attribution, reachable by governance practitioners, and with retention periods specified? If any of the four standards is unmet, Item 4 is not complete.

**Item 5 — Governance floor readiness:** Can the Self's governance practitioners identify the minimum viable governance floor requirements and confirm the Self can satisfy each one? If any floor requirement cannot be confirmed, Item 5 is not complete.

**Item 6 — Exchange bounding capability:** Can the Self's governance practitioners demonstrate the four exchange bounding checks against the content the Self plans to contribute to the first event? If the checks cannot be demonstrated, Item 6 is not complete.

**Item 7 — Home perimeter integrity capability:** Can the Self's governance practitioners demonstrate the three home perimeter integrity checks for the planned event configuration? If the checks cannot be demonstrated, Item 7 is not complete.

**Item 8 — Partner identification:** Has a partner Self been identified that can also demonstrate Items 1–7 complete? If no such partner has been identified, or the partner's readiness has not been assessed, Item 8 is not complete.

**Item 9 — Agreement draft:** Does a draft cross-organizational governance agreement exist that the partner has reviewed? If no draft is in progress, Item 9 is not complete.

**Item 10 — Event configuration draft:** Does a draft first event configuration addressing all six dimensions exist and has the partner reviewed it? If no configuration draft exists, Item 10 is not complete.

**Item 11 — Escalation routing:** Have governance authorities for escalated conflicts been identified and agreed with the partner? If escalation destinations are unspecified, Item 11 is not complete.

**Item 12 — Post-mortem commitment:** Have both parties committed in authored governance content to conduct a post-mortem after the first event? If the commitment is informal or unilateral, Item 12 is not complete.

A Self with all twelve items verified is ready for its first FAI event. A Self with any item outstanding should complete that item before beginning the event, or document and accept the governance risk associated with the gap.

## 6. Conclusion

The FAI governance onboarding checklist consolidates Phase D2’s operational requirements into a practical instrument for governance practitioners preparing a Self for first FAI participation. The twelve items are not a new body of requirements—each derives from a specific Phase D2 note that establishes the requirement and its rationale. The checklist’s contribution is organization: it sequences the requirements into the order in which a governance practitioner would actually build the infrastructure, separates items the Self can complete alone from items requiring partner coordination, and identifies the anti-pattern of unprepared first participation and its specific consequence for governance trust calibration.

The checklist is also reusable. After the first event, the governance infrastructure built through Items 1–7 does not expire—it becomes the Self’s standing governance posture for all subsequent FAI events. Items 8–12 are re-executed for each new partner and each new event, drawing on the standing infrastructure from Stage 1. The post-mortem commitment in Item 12 is the feedback mechanism that improves all twelve items over time. The onboarding checklist is, therefore, not only the gate before the first event—it is the founding document of the Self’s FAI governance practice.

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## How to cite this note

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